

Islay Anderson

Recipe for a Versatile Full-Stack Developer

Ingredients:

Core Profile:

- 1 cup LAMP stack expertise
- ½ cup each of PHP, Python, Next.js, and React
- A full serving of back-end mastery:
 - Data structures
 - APIs
 - Microservices implementation
- A dash of front-end flair plated upon:
 - Web accessibility
 - Optimised CSS/SCSS
- Just a pinch of JavaScript (for the smooth, minimal experience)

Stacks & Technology Mix:

- **WordPress Themes** (garnished with gutenber blocks, ACF, Bones or Bakery)
- **Headless WordPress**
- **LAMP** stack CRUD apps (served in vanilla PHP)
- **Laravel**
- **Next.js & Strapi**
- **Python & Django**

Instructions:

1. **Start with the LAMP base** as the foundation of your full-stack skill set.
2. **Blend in PHP, Python, and JavaScript frameworks** for a well-rounded flavour profile.
3. **Focus on back-end power** by adding structured data handling, efficient API development, and streamlined microservices.
4. **For the front end, mix in accessibility-first designs** using CSS/SCSS to create lightweight, user-friendly experiences with minimal JavaScript.
5. **Season with WordPress themes, Tailwind, and other frameworks** (to taste) to round out your technical menagerie, while **stirring in headless CMS skills** for adaptability.

Serve:

A flexible, full-stack developer, focused on efficient, accessible, and thoughtfully crafted web applications.

EXPERIENCE

SENIOR WEB OFFICER | University of Salford | APRIL 2023 – August 2024

At the University of Salford, I served as the Scrum Master for the web team, overseeing team communication, managing expectations, and providing mentorship and guidance. My primary responsibilities included maintaining the university’s Drupal instance, which powered the main Salford website, and managing a large WordPress network with hundreds of blogs. I also led one-off projects across various tech stacks and collaborated closely with the wider marketing teams, offering solutions and expertise to help achieve their strategic goals. The main part of my role was to ensure the university’s web presence remained compliant (CMA, Accessibility, UKGDPR), aligned with brand standards, and reflective of the institution’s reputation.

WEB DEVELOPER | AGENT | MARCH 2021 – JANUARY 2023

At Agent, I held a broad position, initially brought on for my mid-level development skills and expertise in web accessibility and SEO, particularly with Google products. I worked closely with public sector clients to meet their accessibility requirements, developed custom WordPress themes and headless Next.js applications, created internal tools to support both client projects and our team’s needs, and full ground up PHP CRUD applications like an elearning platform attached to wordpress headlessly as it’s CMS and a case management system for a charity. Additionally, I contributed to SEO and data analysis initiatives and provided mentorship to junior staff and apprentices.

WEB DEVELOPER | FREELANCE | AUGUST 2020 – MARCH 2021

During the first lockdown, I saw an opportunity to try working freelance, procuring work through sites like freelancer.org and submitting work to competitions. This resulted in a few return clients and enough work to sustain myself financially but I found the procuring of work and client interactions challenging.

WEB DEVELOPER | CUMBRIA UNIVERSITY | AUGUST 2019 – AUGUST 2020

First taken on to help complete a web redesign, Accessibility project incomplete by the previous team as well as with developing processes and methods for making changes and updating information for purposes of CMA(Competition and Markets Authority. During my role at Cumbria, I introduced a Kanban system for updating the course information on the website and developed automation tools for auditing the website in accordance with the EU accessibility directive.

JUNIOR DEVELOPER | NOVI.DIGITAL DECEMBER 2015 – APRIL 2019

Initially, my position started as a web development apprentice where I completed a Level 3 and Level 4 “Advanced Apprenticeship in IT, Software, Web & Telecoms Professionals” where I focused on C#.

Around six months into the apprenticeship, a change in staffing meant that I became the only developer for the company, taking on more roles as the sole technical lead for the at the time SE0247 now novi.digital.

In my position at novi, I worked on and spearheaded projects to help the team's workload with automation and to automate manual tasks including a javascript library that can be universally applied to websites and track conversions and interactions granularly into an aggregate funnel to use for making cross sector analysis and informing wider strategy based on overall performance of all our clients.

HOBBIES AND INTERESTS

I enjoy needlework and garment making, crafting unique handmade pieces. Skateboarding and BMX have been lifelong passions since my teenage years, keeping me active and pushing my limits. Fitness and health are central to my life; you’ll often find me working out at the gym, hiking, running, or swimming. I’m also passionate about street photography, especially on film, capturing candid moments and urban scenes that I love to share on my blog.